



Island people

Over 20,000 islands are scattered over the vast expanse of the Pacific Ocean. Some are large, such as New Guinea, others are little more than tiny coral islands. Only a few thousand are inhabited today.

Traditional outrigger canoe.



OUTRIGGER CANOES

The first people to arrive from Southeast Asia moved slowly east in search of new islands to settle. Traveling by outrigger canoe, they were impressive navigators, using the sun, wind, and stars to help them on their journeys. Today, the island people still use the same boats to take them from island to island to trade.

ISLAND INDUSTRY

Small scale industries, such as fishing and some mining, are found on the Pacific islands. However, due to the stunningly beautiful beaches and lagoons, fabulous diving, and fine weather throughout the year, tourism is the main source of income.

Tolai dancers wearing ceremonial masks in Papua New Guinea.



FOREIGN INFLUENCE

Many islanders became Christian when the missionaries arrived in the late 18th century and have since absorbed many foreign influences. Some villages in Papua New Guinea, however, have had little contact with the outside world, and have developed totally different languages and cultures from each other.

LANGUAGE



English is widely spoken throughout Australia, New Zealand, and on many of the Pacific Islands. However, Papua New Guinea lays claim to over 800 different languages!

